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Indulekha Aravind

It was early 2023. In a ground-floor laboratory at the National Centre for Biological Sciences (NCBS) in north Bengaluru, Ph.D candidate Nayan Chakraborty was readying to examine the results of another iteration of an experiment he had been attempting for three months. There was no reason to believe this trial, nearly his 1,000th, would be any different. But when he peered through the microscope, a shocked Chakraborty quickly texted his adviser: “Shashi, we have *jeewanu* in the lab!”

If Chakraborty was taken aback by what he saw, Shashi Thutupalli, who rushed to take a look, was visibly excited. There they were, those tiny blue spheres, just like the ones he had seen in images but was not expecting to see in his own lab. Thutupalli, an associate professor at Centre for Living Machines, NCBS-TIFR (Tata Institute of Fundamental Research) and ICTS-TIFR (International Centre for Theoretical Sciences), had chanced upon these spheres in the little-known but intriguing work of Krishna Bahadur and S. Ranganayaki, chemists, collaborators and life partners who worked at the University of Allahabad half a century ago.

Back in the 1960s, Bahadur had made an incredible claim: that by exposing a chemical mixture to sunlight for a period of time you get spheres that grow, multiply and show metabolic activity, and hence could be considered living units. So convinced was Bahadur that he named these *jeewanu*, meaning particles of life. The claim, and the work, did not go very far – for several reasons. Over the years, *jeewanu*, Bahadur and Ranganayaki faded into oblivion, kept alive mostly in the memories of close family and students.

Lessons in chemistry

That’s where it would likely have remained, if not for the curiosity and efforts of Thutupalli and Chakraborty. The successful attempt in 2023 was followed by three more years of work, the results of which are now out as a preprint (a version of a research paper available publicly before peer review).

In their paper, the duo reports that a mix of four simple compounds – formaldehyde, diammonium molybdate, ferrous sulfate and diammonium hydrogen phosphate – with molybdenum salts acting as a catalyst can self-organise into compartments that show growth, the possibility of multiplication and a rudimentary form of metabolism.

The new work, which involved the development of a minimal recipe, unlike Bahadur’s, and the use of modern techniques, does not claim that these structures, termed protocells – to be understood as a rudimentary, cell-like structure – are a living system, as Bahadur had. Instead, the findings, under peer review, are significant in other ways, from making deep connections to how life on Earth might have started to the possibility of questioning what we look for when we look for life elsewhere.



Shashi Thutupalli (left) and Nayan Chakraborty at the National Centre for Biological Sciences in Bengaluru. (SUDHAKARA JAIN)

better known because the magnitude of their claims makes it unmissable in a sense,” he says.

Bahadur, he went on to find, had published a paper in the international science journal *Nature* in 1954, describing his success with synthesising amino acids using sunlight as a source of energy. Coming soon after the famous Miller-Urey experiment where amino acids were produced from a gaseous mixture using electric discharge, the paper was noticed by important figures in the field. Among them was Soviet biochemist Alexander Oparin, who organised the first international symposium on the origin of life in 1957. Bahadur was one of only two Indians invited, though he eventually did not attend because he did not get a visa. The following year, he had another paper out in *Nature*, on fixing atmospheric nitrogen to make amino acids, using molybdenum as a catalyst.

Then, in the early 60s came

his bold claim about getting *jeewanu*, from a mixture of formaldehyde and a few inorganic salts, particles which he said were compartments, displayed metabolism, growth and reproduction by budding (a type of asexual reproduction) and hence were “living”. It did not seem to have received wide attention, but met with some strong criticism. A 1967 review by two NASA scientists questioned the sterility of the mixtures and concluded that insufficient evidence was offered to prove the claims. Thutupalli could find little mention of the *jeewanu* work after this.

But he was struck by two things: one, that Bahadur and Ranganayaki had been able to get spheres from a mix of salts, which normally yields only crystals. He also felt that the contamination criticism was unconvincing since one of the ingredients was formaldehyde, typically used to preserve specimens. He discussed his findings with Chakraborty.

Unknown to Thutupalli, Chakraborty, a chemist by training, began spending his

evenings and weekends trying out different permutations and combinations of the ingredients. “Even now, Shashi talks about how he had no idea I was doing this for three-four months,” Chakraborty says with a grin.

While the lab work progressed, Thutupalli decided to find out more about the personalities behind *jeewanu*, casting his net wide in the research community. Finally, he found a number for an Ila Bahadur, who turned out to be Bahadur and Ranganayaki’s daughter. “I was so excited, I started talking very fast,” Thutupalli chuckles at the memory of that first conversation. The couple’s four children, it turned out, had preserved as much of their parents’ work as they could. It was not just out of respect for their memory – presciently, their mother had told them that while their work did not get the recognition it deserved, someone might come along later, asking about their research papers.

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SECOND LIFE

A new research finding brings an old experiment exploring life’s origins back into public memory, while also rekindling interest in forgotten scientists Krishna Bahadur and S. Ranganayaki

In the enduring question of how life originated on Earth, an explanation for the transition from non-biological processes to the living state, with extremely complex molecules, remains elusive despite innumerable efforts over the years. The new work tackles one step of this, offering a plausible explanation of how cell-like entities may have formed from a mix of simple compounds.

“You start with very simple stuff, and then you get a compartment that looks like a



The fact that similar structures were found in the ocean suggests there are spots on earth where this kind of chemistry might be facilitated. It’s certainly worthy of more investigation

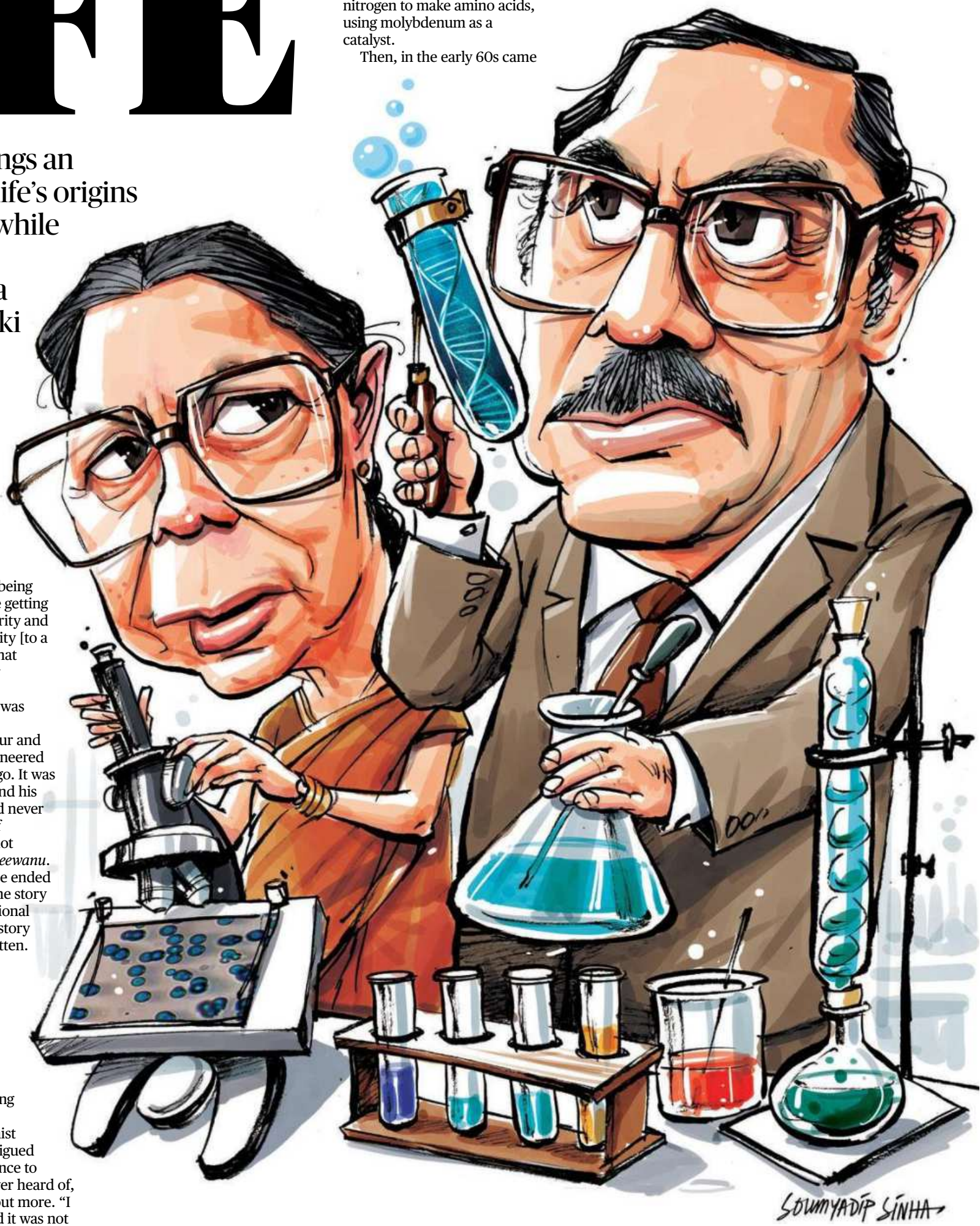
SHASHI THUTUPALLI
Associate professor, Centre for Living Machines, NCBS-TIFR

cell. That’s what makes it scientifically remarkable,” says Thutupalli, gesturing animatedly. “In the process, lipid-like and amino acid-like compounds are being made. So, you’re getting structural similarity and chemical similarity [to a cell], which is what makes this triply exciting.”

This, he says, was inspired by the approach Bahadur and Ranganayaki pioneered all those years ago. It was also a route he and his colleagues would never have explored, if Thutupalli had not stumbled upon *jeewanu*. Along the way, he ended up uncovering the story of an unconventional couple whom history had all but forgotten.

A chance encounter

Thutupalli first came across the names of Bahadur and Ranganayaki in 2019 while reading the work of Hungarian chemist Tibor Ganti. Intrigued by Ganti’s reference to work he had never heard of, he tried to find out more. “I was very puzzled it was not



Soumyadip Sinha



Chintan Girish Modi

Have you ever stepped out of a cinema hall, wanting to run back and catch the next show of the same movie? That's how one feels after reading Sarnath Banerjee's latest graphic novel *Absolute Jafar* (HarperCollins India), a romance between Brighu from India and Mahrukh from Pakistan, which unfolds across Delhi, Chicago, Karachi and Berlin. The trauma that borders cause, moments of tenderness, wacky humour, and cinematic references pull one into the world that Banerjee has constructed.

The public curiosity about the cross-border relationship owes also to the fact that Banerjee was once married to Pakistani artist Bani Abidi. That said, tracking down autobiographical material instead of relishing how the author has transformed it into art is probably the worst way to read this book.

"Even if *Absolute Jafar* is about many things, such as childhood, the idea of home, relocation, fantasies of urban living, walking, music, clashing modernities, local universes, history of how a people felt at a certain time, the line of inquiry invariably boils down to the Indo-Pak aspect of it," Banerjee laments. "Someone even asked me if my book, which I started writing seven years ago, was influenced by *Dhurandhar*," he adds, referring to the recent Bollywood blockbuster about an Indian intelligence agent who infiltrates Pakistan to dismantle a terror network. Edited excerpts from an email conversation:

Question: How does it feel to write an India-Pakistan love story in the current political environment where diplomatic



IN CONVERSATION

AN INDO-PAK LOVE COMIC

Graphic novelist Sarnath Banerjee on his new cross-border story and the mistaken comparisons to *Dhurandhar*



great power over your life, etc. It's not as if you plan such a thing, marry a Pakistani just to show how radical you are. Love just happens. Ordinary people just want to live ordinary lives, even if they make an unconventional decision. But here they get mixed up in bilateral politics. The marriage feels a bit like an autoimmune disease, even many years after it ends.

Q: Unlike Brighu and Mahrukh, their son Jafar appears completely free from the weight of history and geopolitics. What enables this?

A: He is growing up with an imagination of the 'other'. Different people, locations, street food, ways of existence and listening to different music. His existence is local and highly actualised. From

Fridays for Future to going to pro-Palestine demonstrations in Berlin, from his *nani*'s poetry club in Karachi to the Saraswati puja at his other grandmother's house in Calcutta, from walking the streets of north Calcutta, as if his grandfather owned a homeopathy shop there, to going to *marsias* in Berlin during Muharram. This gives him a natural ease in dealing with diversity and a strange lightness. This feeling of being intensely local in different places is, perhaps, what is called post-identity.

Q: Brighu's father used to play Ustad Vilayat Khan's music to wake him up. Brighu plays Lucky Ali to wake up Jafar. How did you end up exploring music as a love language?

A: Father-son relationships

Panels from *Absolute Jafar*, and (below) artist-author Sarnath Banerjee.

have changed over the years. Sure, there has always been love, respect, and, sometimes, shared interests such as sports and music, but father and son didn't share an imagination space. Fathers became tax, job and property advisers. I feel things are different now.

I am no longer a figure of absolute authority to my son; he is not subordinate to my ideas and politics. He challenges them, questions me and, sometimes, calls me out. I feel this respectful insubordination is key to a healthy society. A child mustn't have to agree to their father's worldview. As we grow older, we become more conservative, and unconditionally agreeing to such a person's opinion ensures a conservative society. India is a prime example. Children should be raised to have an independent mind. Yes, they are ours, but also different from us.

Q: What do you think about the possibility of your graphic novels being used to train generative AI models that can later produce new stories and images mimicking your style but customised to user prompts?

A: It wasn't for no reason that Japanese animator Miyazaki said that AI is anti-life. AI is like the death drag of a middle-aged man who has given up on life. It would take away the last shred of humanity from us and serenade the world to its end.

AI apologists believe that it would democratise art. They have no idea of what it involves to make art. They think it's the final product. AI can produce the final product swiftly and perhaps better than any human being. They don't realise that the final product is the least important part of art-making. It is the process that is the most precious. AI takes away the process, and the pleasures and joys of life. The uncritical champions of AI have outsourced their imagination.

Luckily, my work is not mainstream enough for them to fully get into. I have a very small audience. Currently, AI is only interested in highly distributed, easily available work.

The interviewer is a writer, educator and literary critic. His work has appeared in the anthologies *Fearless Love* and *Bent Book*.

ONE FOR THE ROAD

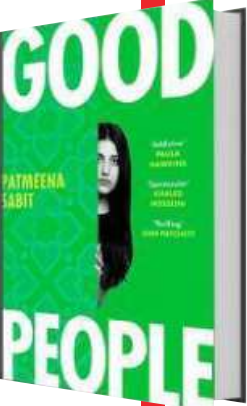
Peak storytelling

Bold, experimental narratives that keep you turning the pages

Swati Daftuar

There is much pleasure in fiction that does something new and unexpected – but nearly as much in stories that take a familiar premise and truly make it their own. This month's stack is packed with books that are fresh, experimental, unexpected. Find in them first loves and old shadows, dark, feral family dramas, and food, faith and longing. Rich in texture and nerve, they carry the quiet assurance of writers who know exactly the stories they want to tell.

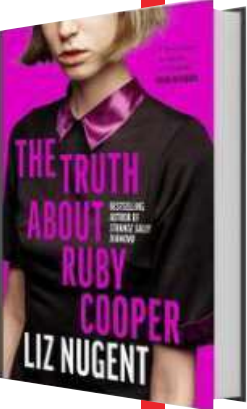
Good People | Patmeena Sabit



Zorah Sharaf is dead before the story begins, but she's on every page of this book. Debut novelist Sabit gives us a chorus of voices piecing together the life and circling the death of a young Afghan American woman. What kind of girl was Zorah? Everyone knows, or think they do. Sabit handles the multiple perspectives with confidence and what we get in return is a portrait of community, control and reputation.

Virago; ₹799

The Truth About Ruby Cooper | Liz Nugent



Ruby Cooper grows up in a tightly wound, religious family in Boston, in the shadow of her beautiful older sister Erin. Nugent's books always get to the crux quickly, so here too, right from the beginning, you can feel the damage, the wounds and the darkness. This is a story of escalating jealousy, accusation, betrayal, and all the harm that families can do. Nugent is superb at writing characters who are difficult and impossible to dismiss, and Ruby is one of her sharpest creations yet.

Penguin; ₹899

Just Friends | Haley Pham



Second-chance romances, at their best, are quietly affecting – so long as they don't turn saccharine. This one avoids that trap, carrying more ache than fluff. Blair returns to her coastal hometown to be with the dying great-aunt who helped raise her, and soon runs into Declan, the boy who once felt like home. Their shared past – friendship, first love, an accident – lingers in every encounter, infusing the story with plenty of chemistry. It makes for an easy, comforting read, but one with enough emotional depth to keep its warmth from becoming cloying.

Simon & Schuster; ₹499

Motherfucker | Anna Brook-Mitchell



Barri's marriage has fallen apart, and her life is beginning to unravel. In a moment of desperation, she lies about being pregnant, but this lie will grow legs and get away from her. There's a lot of farce here – fake bumps, miscommunication, situational comedy, escalating chaos. It could have been too much, but it helps that Brook-Mitchell knows how to balance a ridiculous premise with real sorrow. A mischievous read with a sharp eye for social absurdities and hypocrisy.

Pan Macmillan; ₹799

Mumbai Marathon | Aarambh M. Singh



Singh uses an interesting framework for his debut novel: the Mumbai Marathon, and within it, the stories of seven women. This is a narrative defined by movement, not just of the body, but of ambition and desire. We get action, but also the inner worlds of the characters Singh creates – each woman's ambition, grief, fatigue, the need to be seen, the need simply to keep going. Singh, who comes from a film background, has a good understanding of pacing, with the novel investing in details, silence and accumulation over grand revelation.

Penguin; ₹499

(A monthly column on popular fiction.)

The writer is an independent journalist, editor, and literary curator.

Voices from the black soil

This translation of Ki.Ra.'s celebrated Tamil novel brings alive the *karisal* landscape for English readers

Sudha G. Tilak

When *People of Gopallapuram* (the English translation of Ki. Rajanarayanan's celebrated Tamil novel *Gopalapurathu Makkal*) arrives in readers' hands this year, it feels like a much-awaited passage into a world that Tamil literature has cherished for long, and reaffirms the power of regional literature in a national canon.

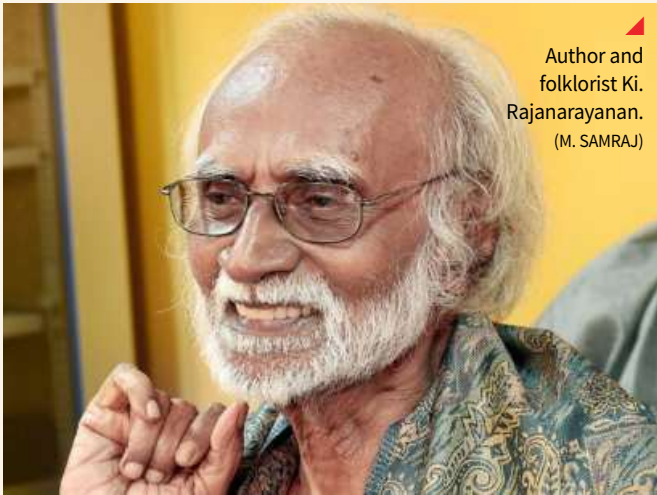
Published under the laudatory initiative of the Tamil Nadu Textbook and Educational Services Corporation, the novel opens a window into rural South India on the cusp of seismic change, at the twilight of British rule and the dawn of Independence.

Ki. Rajanarayanan (1923-2021), better known as Ki.Ra., was not just a novelist but a cultural cartographer of the *karisal*, or chernozem, the "black earth" region of

southern Tamil Nadu. He is widely regarded as the doyen of *karisal kaatu* literature, a body of work distinguished by its rootedness in local dialect, folk practice, agrarian struggle and an unvarnished humanism that refuses romanticisation. These scorched plains and the people who eked out their lives there became the wellspring for his lifework.

Community and chaos *People of Gopallapuram* is a communal portrait first and then a conventional novel. The eponymous village, and its rhythms, assemblies, lovers, farmers, artisans, caste divisions and labourers, nationalists and rebels, all become the narrative's beating heart.

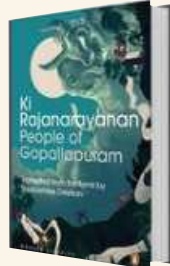
The novel traces how the everyday realities of caste, custom and economic precarity play out against the backdrop of the nation's freedom. Village elders linger over memory, lovers chafe against separation, and serfs



Author and folklorist Ki. Rajanarayanan. (M. SAMRAJ)

negotiate the uneasy pull between continuity and change.

In Ki.Ra.'s world, the non-human is never merely backdrop: bulls and birds, earth and plough, rain and drought, cotton and cacti, toddy and tongues breathe alongside the people, shaping their fates as



People of Gopallapuram
Ki Rajanarayanan;
trs Shubashree Desikan
Penguin
₹499

intimately as kin.

Equally vivid are the passing spectacles of a changing India – the awe of steam engines slicing through the landscape, the ambivalence toward colonial education, the murmurs of gossip and the hum of gatherings. Community and chaos coexist here, rendered with a gaze that is at once affectionate, ironic and deeply humane. The novel's strength lies not in dramatic plot twists but in its panoramic empathy.

Conversations in the wind Shubashree Desikan's rendering of Ki.Ra.'s Tamil offers a glossary to English readers to understand the texture of spoken language, more like a phrasebook that explains the idiosyncrasies of speech that make the novel's

voices distinct. This careful calibration is crucial, for much of Ki.Ra.'s power as a writer lies in the ordinariness of his characters, their quotidian struggles rendered with depth and compassion and his ironic humour.

The translation enlarges both Ki.Ra.'s reach and the presence of South India's rural imaginations in Indian literary discourse. It also complements other efforts in Tamil – from the incisive social explorations of Pudhumaipithan to the poetic terrains charted by T. Janakiraman, the grit of Imayam and Perumal Murugan by foregrounding a literary geography where earth, toil, tongue and myth converge.

Ultimately, *People of Gopallapuram* is not driven by plot but by presence and the accumulation of lives, landscapes, moments and folk cosmologies that together form a richly inhabited world. It reminds us that history is not only written in capitals and proclamations, but lived in villages, in fields, in conversations carried by the wind and in the black soil that holds, and remembers, everything.

The reviewer is the author of *Temple Tales* and translator of Hungry Humans.

The smiling assassin

Mark Hodgkinson's book is not for tennis nerds, but fans of the young champion won't want to miss it

G. Sampath
sampath.g@thehindu.co.in

One of the toughest feats in tennis is the 'Channel Slam' – winning the French Open and Wimbledon in the same year. Separated by the English Channel, the high-bouncing red clay of the French Open and the slippery grass of Wimbledon are only two hours apart by Eurostar. Yet the demands they make on an athlete could not be more divergent. Transitioning from one to the other calls for not only greater range in skill, but also higher capacity for adjustment – in physicality, movement, tactics, stamina, and even mindset. But a player gets barely three weeks to remodel his game – the shortest of intervals between two Slams on the tennis calendar. Any coach would want his ward to make the most of this limited training window.

In the summer of 2024, that is exactly what Carlos Alcaraz's coach Juan Carlos Ferrero wanted from him after he won the French Open – to start training immediately for

from the other greats of the sport. It also explains why Alcaraz is the only top player who can smile in the tensest moments of a Grand Slam final, after losing an important point.

Critics have complained that Alcaraz tends to let showmanship – entertaining the crowd with fancy shots – come in the way of winning. They view his smiles as betraying a lack of seriousness. But as Hodgkinson demonstrates in a lengthy chapter on the Alcaraz smile, it is when he is smiling that he is most dangerous.

At it happened, Alcaraz did make it to the 2024 Wimbledon final, his detour to Ibiza notwithstanding. He led his opponent, Novak Djokovic, by two sets to love, and was serving at 5-4, 40-0, when he got broken. As Hodgkinson notes, "That was a dangerous moment for Alcaraz... it would have been very, very, easy, given everything that was on the line, to have spiralled mentally." However, belying the tension on Ferrero's face, "Alcaraz smiled in the tiebreak as he prepared for his fourth championship point." He converted it and became the youngest-ever Channel Slam winner. Joy and freedom had won over discipline and "slavery" to tennis.

Only someone with tremendous mental toughness could have pulled it off. How did Alcaraz develop it? His parents have been taking him to a psychologist since he was eight, and it has kept his personality grounded, and his mind clutter-free.

It was probably this clarity of thought, and the differences in their attitude to tennis, that explains Alcaraz's decision to part ways with Ferrero last December. Questions swirled around the move, but his triumph at the 2026 Australian Open, without Ferrero by his side, proved that he was his own man now, and his own kind of champion. If Rafael Nadal was the warrior, Djokovic the surgeon, and Roger Federer the artist, then Alcaraz is the smiling assassin whose thunderous forehands as much as his silky drop shots can leave the opponent exasperated and applauding at the same time.

Being Carlos Alcaraz is light on the tennis aspect, dwelling more on Alcaraz's relationships with those in his inner circle. It doesn't pack enough to hold the interest of the tennis nerd. But diehard Alcaraz fans wouldn't want to miss it.

Being Carlos Alcaraz: The Man Behind The Smile
Mark Hodgkinson
Hachette
₹699

Wimbledon. The stakes were high. Alcaraz had a golden opportunity to become the youngest to achieve the Channel Slam. But the (then) 21-year-old had other ideas. Defying his coach, he took off to celebrate his Roland Garros title by getting "wasted" in Ibiza, Spain's party hotspot.

As the late tennis journalist Mark Hodgkinson writes in *Being Carlos Alcaraz: The Man Behind The Smile*, "It was a holiday that made Ferrero think that he and Alcaraz have very different approaches to 'work and sacrifice'. Ferrero was left questioning whether Alcaraz had the discipline to achieve his ambition of becoming the greatest tennis player in history."

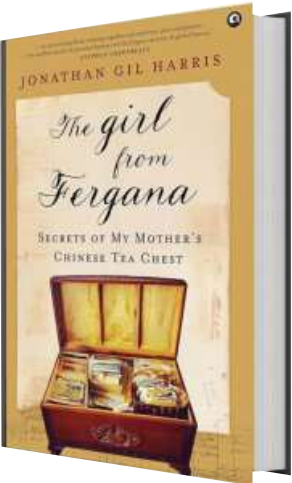
The difference in mindset and personality between the champion and his legendary coach is one of the more fascinating sub-plots of the Alcaraz story explored in this biography. Ferrero had a "ferocious work ethic", and believed that "to be the best, Alcaraz must be willing to be 'a slave' to tennis." But Alcaraz, observes Hodgkinson, "won't ever be enslaved by tennis". He plays tennis because he is in love with it. The sheer joy permeating the free-flowing creativity of his game style is perhaps what sets him apart



Carlos Alcaraz became the youngest man to complete a career Grand Slam. (GETTY IMAGES)



The Girl From Fergana: Secrets of My Mother's Chinese Tea Chest
Jonathan Gil Harris
Aleph
₹899



AN ELEGY FOR A SYNCRETIC WORLD

With the help of his Jewish war-refugee mother's material history, Jonathan Gil Harris traces how borders shape and distort people

Sumana Mukherjee

It is, perhaps, a truism that we spend half our lives running away from our mothers. And the other half, running towards them. Frequently, the latter happens when they are no longer around, when, through the mundane task of clearing up, the children discover facets of them long buried beneath the visible surface. So few of us realise our parents were whole people before we came along, with stories and passions and mistakes – and when we do, it is often too late to ask them anything about how those experiences shaped them.

Not so for Jonathan Gil Harris. His parents were still around when he began working on what was then titled *The Jewish Silk Roads: Secrets of My Mother's Tea Chest*. Already, though, he was losing her to the slow progress of Alzheimer's. Possibly the disease was the reason why Harris felt the urge to move away from Shakespeare and early modern globalisation – the subject matters of his 10-plus previous books – and look closer home, in an effort to piece her together when she seemed to be coming apart. In less accomplished hands and with a less remarkable subject, the story could have been a sentimental celebration of maternal love, or a layered depiction of a mother-son relationship, or a simple recording of her memories – something treasured and brought out at family gatherings, and marked with a smile and a tear.

The Girl from Fergana (as the work-in-progress title evolved into) is none of the above. There is no mawkishness about it, no sanding over the hard bits, no attempt to ignore the uncomfortable. Instead, Harris places his mother Stella's story in the larger narrative of a dying civilisation. And incredibly, he manages to make it urgent, pertinent, and relevant to the present moment, as bombs and missiles fire over West Asia and lives are lost in a trumped-up war.

It was another war that



People living in the highlands bordering the city of Fergana Valley in Jalal-Abad, Kyrgyzstan, practise agriculture and animal husbandry and continue to lead a traditional way of life. (GETTY IMAGES)

uprooted a little girl called Shulamit (later, Stella) in 1939. Along with her older sister Maryska and their mother, Lola Freud, she travelled from her safe, prosperous home in Nazi-threatened Warsaw to her father, then stationed east, in Lwow, now Lviv, in Ukraine. It is a bald fact, with few distinguishing features from scores of other such stories, but Harris's particular genius is context. Why was Natan Freud (yes, there is a connection to the most famous Freud) in Lwow at all? And that question leads to a vast, ancient web of cultural and economic connections that spread across eastern Europe, central Asia, and into India and China, which Harris calls the Jewish Silk Roads.

Of all the major world

religions undergoing a metamorphosis right now, perhaps none is as contested or precipitously poised as the Judaism/Zionism balance. As vividly as Harris portrays development and change in the trade routes across millennia, he also gently builds a poignant, layered, yet objective history of the Jewish people. Diasporic by nature, they thrived in the organically plural world of trade. They were successful, consequently powerful, and thus often regarded with suspicion in their adopted homes. After World War II, when antisemitism triggered another exodus of Holocaust survivors from Europe, and the imperialist states of Britain and France conspired to settle them on land taken from Arab tribes in West

Asia, they were, Harris seems to suggest, condemned to turn the tables on a convenient "other", the very position they had once occupied – the ramifications of which play out to this day.

Refreshingly unafraid of showcasing his erudition, Harris uses philology, etymology, sociology, theology, history, literature, and geography to deepen and widen the narrative. In parallel, he draws on his mother's experiences, specifically the years when the refugee family learnt to survive first in a Soviet gulag and then in the small market town of Uzgen in the Fergana Valley, to humanise a story that is often too large and too awful to comprehend. Harris's method of illustrating a point of history through an object retrieved from the Chinese tea chest of the title is rather beautiful. Part learned academic, part diligent investigator, part curious son, he eagerly derives meaning from the silent and the unsaid – the rich draperies in one faded photograph, a watercolour painting of a Cairo street scene in another – sometimes making small, romantic leaps in educated judgment and at other times providing chapter and verse for his conclusions.

"Stella was an archivist of her own past," Harris writes. "Albeit one who could not bear to return to her archives. It was as if the tea chest and its folded papers had expanded to colonise her entire living space." By unpacking the tea chest in *The Girl from Fergana* (I have a bit of a pedantic issue with the title though: as catchy as it is, in the text it refers to a young Muslim who becomes Shulamit/Stella's closest friend in Uzgen), Harris traces how borders – in their artifice, their politics, and their power – have shaped and distorted people over millennia.

An elegy for a syncretic world, *The Girl from Fergana* creates space for Harris's mother – innocent, flawed, survivor, Zionist – and, in the process, makes each of us a little bit more human again.

The reviewer is a writer and editor based in Bengaluru.

BROWSER

Maya: The Biography of a Tiger

Anant Sonawane
HarperCollins
₹699
Author and environmental conservation communicator Anant Sonawane explores the life of Maya, one of the most beloved tigresses of Maharashtra's Tadoba-Andhari reserve, who vanished without a trace in 2023.



First Bite: Breakfast Stories from Urban India

Priyadarshini Chatterjee
Speaking Tiger
₹699
Food, culture, and travel writer Priyadarshini Chatterjee uses breakfast as a lens to understand how cities function and how foodways are shaped by labour, migration, caste, class, faith, colonialism, and capitalism. She blends food history with cultural reportage.



Under Grey Smoggy Skies

Harsh Mander
Yoda Press
₹499
Author, researcher, teacher, and social activist Harsh Mander started the Karwan-e-Mohabbat campaign in solidarity with victims of communal or religiously motivated violence. This book draws on his work with the urban homeless.



Umar Khalid and his World: An Anthology

Edited by Anirban Bhattacharya, Banjojyotsna Lahiri, Shuddhabrata Sengupta
Three Essays Collective
₹750
This anthology on and by Umar Khalid has contributions from scholars, journalists, lawyers, human-rights activists, and fellow UAPA prisoners.





CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

The records, books and letters, now part of the archives at NCBS, also reveal the extent of the indignity Bahadur had to endure, indicating at least one possible reason for the muted response to his and Ranganayaki's work.

Against all odds Bahadur and Ranganayaki, Ila recounts, met at the University of Allahabad, where they were both students of N.R. Dhar, the well-known professor of chemistry. Ranganayaki, who was from Chidambaram in Tamil Nadu, married Bahadur against her parents' wishes. The couple collaborated in their research, starting with amino acid synthesis and publishing papers together. So involved were they in their work that when Ranganayaki was hospitalised for a fortnight, their students set up the experiment in a ward with sunlight so that they could keep going.

"For us, it was not unusual – this was part of life," says Ila. The first paper on *jeewanu* was published before she was born. But as she got older, she became conscious of the shadow cast by the criticism of her parents' work. "My mother was more vocal about her anger over people not accepting their work. My father used to keep quiet, but he was sad," she says. In his 2011 paper 'Jeewanu, or the 'particles of life'', Mathias Grote, a historian of science who examined the work from a historical perspective, discusses the reception to *jeewanu*. He writes that Hungarian scientist Ganti's explanation of why the scientific community was either ignorant or dismissive of Bahadur's work was explicit: "Bahadur and his co-workers believe that Jeewanus live... However, the scientific world believes that they are inanimate artefacts and it does not even consider the results, let alone tries to disprove them... The belief of the scientific world is based on prejudice. It is prejudice, first against the unusual, unexpected, and strange experimental results, and second against the modest, too simple, and hardly equipped experimental methods."

Grote himself writes that whether one considers it a drawback or a virtue, Bahadur did not stick to the work style of his time. He used technically simple equipment, "varying the protocols frequently and documenting them somewhat idiosyncratically". The fact that the four main papers on *jeewanu* appeared in a little-known German journal may also have limited its reach. Then there was the 1967 review of the work co-authored by Sri Lankan biochemist Cyril Ponnamperuma, a leading figure at NASA's exobiology division at the time. The review said the experimental procedures were presented in a confusing manner, questioned the sterility of the mixtures, and concluded that the "nature and properties of the *jeewanu* remains to be clarified". This critique, writes Grote, "was fierce and probably influential".

Bahadur's correspondence, now public for the first time, reveals more. His papers in *Nature*

SECOND LIFE



had attracted the attention of Sidney W. Fox, a prominent biochemist in the U.S. Bahadur accepts the invitation to work in his lab but then the two fall out and Bahadur returns to India. Fox insists that the experiment results cannot be repeated, based on his students' attempts. But he does not stop there. In a response addressed to Bahadur in 1963 but also sent to several others, he writes: "... a hurried and careless treatment of a subject of such importance is potentially a crime against all humanity", going on to add, "Our considered judgement here is that you have deceived yourself in your own observations." He ends the letter by writing: "I regret indeed that you have so allowed yourself to be blinded to reality." Among the recipients of the communication was NASA's Ponnampertuma. While it's hard to state with certainty why Bahadur's work was not received favourably, Thutupalli says it does seem reasonable and likely that the criticism of these important scientists would have played a big role. There's also the fact that extraordinary claims



I feel like this is a constant problem in the sciences, that if you happen to belong to certain advanced nations and come from well-ranked institutes in that part of the world, your research is taken more seriously

SUDHA RAJAMANI Professor, IISER Pune

these *jeewanu*-like entities could have also played a role in early processes that set the stage for the transition from chemistry to biology on the early Earth. Like many others, Rajamani was unaware of Bahadur's research, hearing of it only a decade ago. "I feel like this is a constant problem in the sciences, that if you happen to belong to certain advanced nations and come from well-ranked institutes in that part of the world, your research is taken more seriously," she says.

Some, though, are sceptical. Discussing the work of Bahadur and some of his peers, Henderson Cleaves, professor and chair, department of chemistry, Howard University, who tried years ago to reproduce Bahadur's work with what he terms mixed results (it yielded microscopic structures but not specific molecules) says it appears easy to mix some chemicals in a test tube, look at the results, see that there are small cell-like structures and then claim you have made life in a test tube. The fact that there is "no good working definition of life" makes it extremely hard to prove that whatever these scientists find fits it, he says.

In his view, the history of scientists like Bahadur involved a great deal of "seeing what you want to see". He adds that while he is happy someone else is re-examining Bahadur's experiments, he thinks the new work is falling into the same "cognitive traps". In response, Thutupalli emphasises that they are certainly not claiming to have synthesised life in the lab. "The data we present is unambiguous in showing that compartments and complexifying chemistry self-organise from very simple initial conditions," he says. Interestingly, in July 2024, a paper by marine biologists reported the discovery of blue spheres within sponges in the ocean. The NCBS researchers found that the structures they made in the lab and those discovered in the ocean shared similarities in atomic composition – both have an abundant amount of molybdenum and significant amounts of carbon, oxygen and phosphorus. "The fact that similar structures were found in the ocean suggests there are spots on earth where this kind of chemistry might be facilitated. It's certainly worthy of more investigation," says Thutupalli.

What lies ahead?

Both Thutupalli and Chakraborty hope that once their paper is peer reviewed, more researchers will build on it. "The biggest achievement will be other scientists picking up this work – because science is a social, collaborative process," says Chakraborty. "It will be much more reproducible and rigorous when groups around the world do it."

Philippe Nghe, a professor at the Ecole Polytechnique's Structural Biology of the Cell Laboratory in France, who's exploring the role of RNA in the origin of life, says the fact that their work combines two elements that are essential for the emergence of life makes it interesting. "The study proposes a plausible route by which simple chemical mixtures, under generic conditions, could generate both catalytic chemistry and compartmentalisation – key ingredients required for chemical systems to eventually undergo selection and evolution," he says.

According to Sudha Rajamani, professor of biology at IISER Pune, the work opens up potentially new possibilities in thinking about how

Aastha D.

At the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) in New Delhi, modern artist Satish Gujral's centenary retrospective opens with a video of a river rushing between rocks, and his voice recalling the swimming accident in Kashmir's Lidder river that took his hearing at eight. "The pain was traumatic. It numbed my senses. Slowly, it took away my hearing."

Then the galleries open, and the exhibition *Satish Gujral 100* never stops insisting on more, refusing to resolve. Paintings, sculptures, burnt wood, tapestries, murals, architectural models, erotic compositions, horses, zebras, late luminous canvases full of rams and arced forms, made after a cochlear implant briefly returned his hearing. Over 160 works, seven decades, and every medium imaginable. The concentrated output of a mind for whom silence made the world explode outward into form, surface, weight, a voracious insistence on making.

The range hits you as affect – as pressure and sensation on the body – before it hits you as biography. Pain, whimsy, ego, arrogance, guilt, anger, eroticism, nostalgia for the future – it is all here, arriving simultaneously. Then the thought arrives as punctuation: all of this was made in silence. The restlessness of a man moving through every medium he could reach tells you that one lifetime was not enough.

Summer of Partition

Gujral (1925-2020) was born in Jhelum, in what is now Pakistan, into a family of pronounced civic ambition. His father, Avtar Narain Gujral, was a lawyer who

had remade himself as a Gandhian activist – trading the anglicised professional's coat for the austerity of Lala Lajpat Rai's *Servants of the People Society* – and a politician with connections on both sides of what would soon become an unbridgeable divide. His elder brother Inder Kumar Gujral would eventually become Prime Minister of India.

The family's privilege was both insulating and real at a critical moment. When Partition arrived, Avtar Narain used political connections and police protection to organise safe passage for refugees. The young Satish Gujral, just 22, transported abandoned women and children

across the border to camps.

Gujral held that summer in his body and his work for the rest of his life. The 1950s canvases, such as *Mourning En-Masse* and the *Partition* series, are made of that grief: compressed figures, faces pulled past recognisability, a sorrow so dense the canvas barely contains it.

Lessons from Diego and Frida Kahlo

His accident had already changed the nature of his relationship to the world. Progressive hearing loss through childhood meant that the world reached him primarily through touch and material. His canvases

from the early 1960s solicit the hand as much as the eye. Everything carries the sculptural quality of a mind that thinks in mass and void, weight and temperament.

In 1952, he went to Mexico City, where he became friends with Diego Rivera, Frida Kahlo's husband, and the most politically charged muralist of his century. Rivera was a man of volcanic conviction and difficult temperament, who believed art's proper place was on public walls – legible to everyone who moved through shared space. Kahlo, today considerably more famous than her husband, made a different and equally ferocious

argument in paint: the body as primary historical document; damage and desire confronted without mediation.

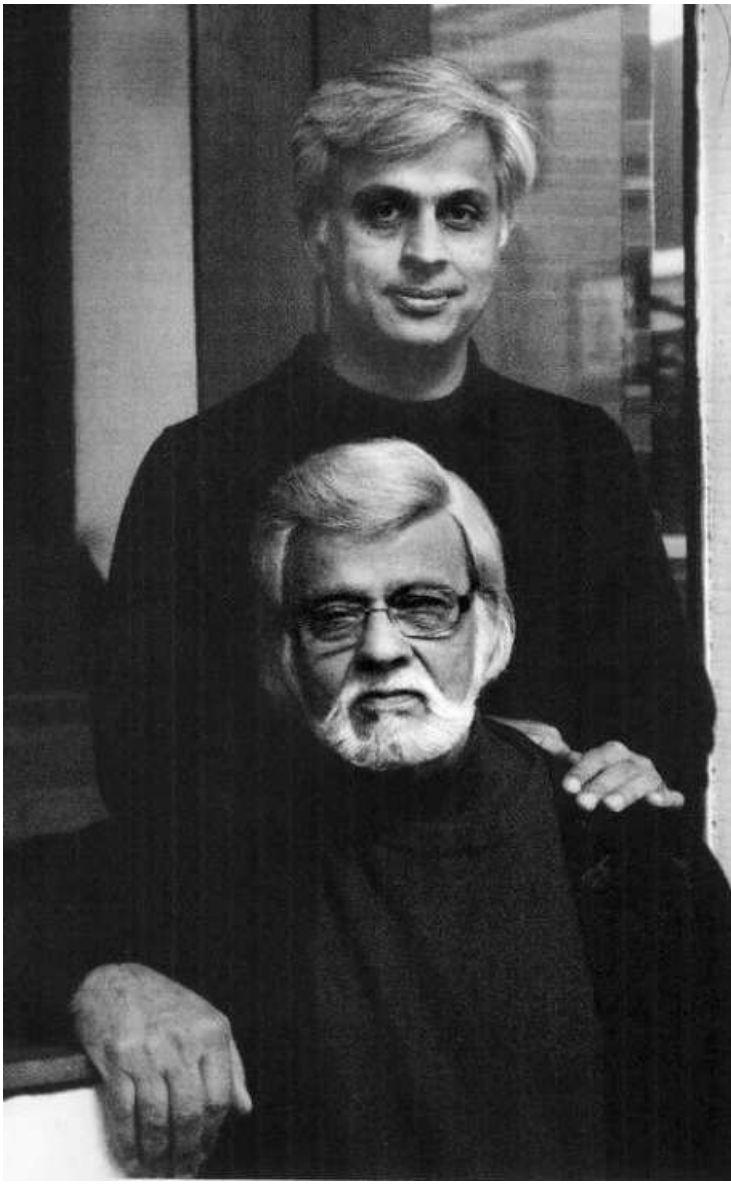
Gujral absorbed the conviction: that art could carry history, grief, and politics simultaneously, at public scale. He came back a muralist, taking abstraction for the first time onto public walls across New Delhi.

'Making things from pain and memory' Gujral absorbed the conviction: that art could carry history, grief, and politics simultaneously, at public scale. He came back a muralist, taking abstraction for the first time onto public walls across New Delhi.



SATHISH GUJRAL: A SILENCE THAT EXPLODED

His hearing loss didn't stop him, it made the world erupt outward into form, surface, a voracious insistence on making. The artist's centenary retrospective showcases this output



(Clockwise from left) Gujral House; Satish Gujral with his son Mohit; the exhibition *Satish Gujral 100* at the NGMA; and an exhibit from *World of Architecture*. (COURTESY GUJRAL FOUNDATION, SACHIN SONI)

attended to his practice.

At Gujral House in Lajpat Nagar III, a parallel exhibition, *World of Architecture*, unfolds – photographs, blueprints, films, and sketches spread across its basement, ground, and first floors. Inside, there is a cylindrical structure capped by a dome that was Kiran's dressing room. She shaped the space and inhabited it. It stands now in a public exhibition of Gujral's work, its intimate function dissolved, its authorship invisible. She made work that holds the building together. The archive remembers the man who filled the world with form.

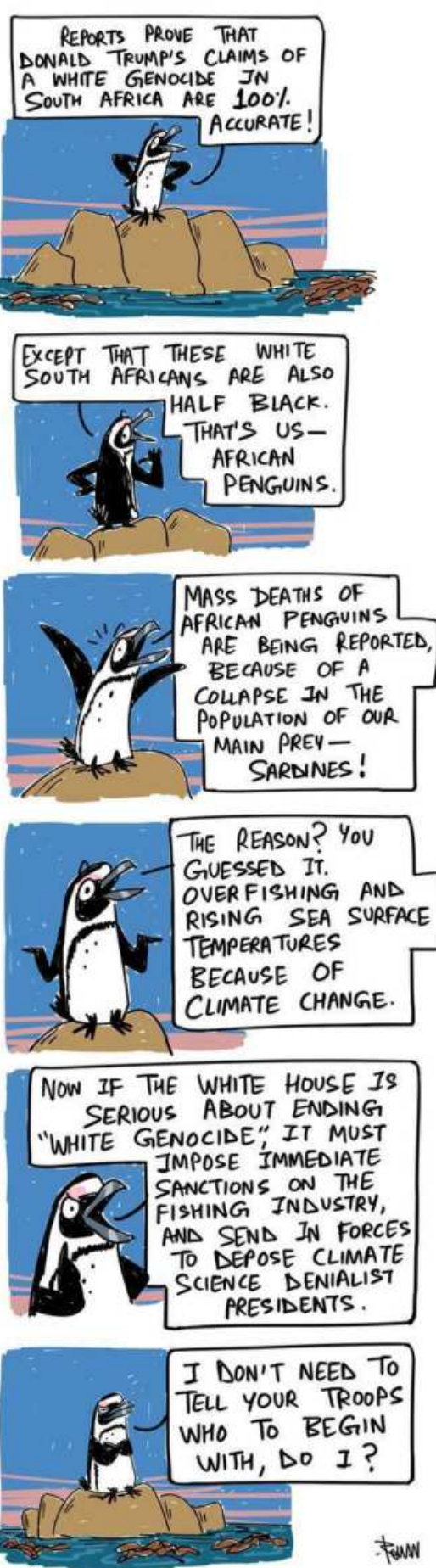
Gujral built a language inside his silence – made of surface and weight and mass and the pressure of a reality that kept insisting on being made into something – and it had turned out to be inexhaustible.

Satish Gujral 100 is on till April 15 at NGMA.

The essayist-educator writes on culture, and is founding editor of Prosestry – a literary arts magazine.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakraborty



Subha J Rao

Thaai Kizhavi, revolving around the elderly Pavunthaaya (played effortlessly by Radikaa Sarathkumar), has grossed more than ₹75 crore worldwide at the box office, powered by women and family audiences. Released last month and running successfully in theatres, the film, directed by Sivakumar Murugesan and produced by actor Sivakartheeyan, will likely drop on JioHotstar in April.

What is being seen as a bigger power move is that Radikaa, as part of her contract, has received a share in the film's profit, thus becoming the first actress in the history of Tamil cinema to do so. "I said I wanted to be paid more, because I deserve it. And, we decided on profit sharing. I think all actors should follow this. So many younger actresses have called to say this gives them immense confidence. All I tell them is to build your space, and hold on to it," she says.

Radikaa knows the importance of the space she is speaking about. The actor, who has made a mark across film industries in India (primarily Tamil, Telugu, Hindi and Kannada) and ruled regional television for many years, beginning with the serial *Chithi*, has come a long way from her debut as Paanjalai in Bharathiraja's 1978 Tamil hit *Kizhakke Pogum Rail*. Hindi film-viewers will recall her as Rishi Kapoor's naive village-wife with an upturned plait from *Naseeb Apna Apna* (1986). In the 48 years since her debut, she's been exploring new frontiers and paving paths. She also won a National Award in 1985 for producing the poignant *Meendum Oru Kaadhal Kadhai*. And, with *Thaai Kizhavi*, she proves that a progressive film headlined by a 63-year-old woman can rake in the moolah, too.

Pavunthaaya speaks of why women must be educated, prudent and good with finances, and also enjoy their life. An interesting montage shows this matriarch of Ustilampatti watching movies and blowing bubbles during her outings to the city. Radikaa says she had almost rejected the film at first. "After reading the script, I was certain I'd be typecast. But Sivakumar showed up at my office for a year-and-a-half, hoping to



persuade me. I agreed on the condition that the prosthetics be good. The depth of my role – something so empowering – mattered more to me than the screen time. I was able to own my character's identity. And, people saw her truth. It is possible to make a choice without being boxed."

Age is just a number

Radikaa, whose social media pages celebrate every aspect of her life, including grandmotherhood, says, "I don't think I become less

interesting with age. I look at things differently. I don't want to be the youngest in the frame, but I want my presence to bring more strength to the frame." A Radikaa-starrer doing well at the box office is important because films are not very kind to ageing heroines. "It usually meant disappearance, a quiet exit into oblivion. Strong roles were written for women. But someone was deciding what women need to do in movies. Which is why I decided I would be in control, and started my own production company after

The Radikaa Sarathkumar-starrer *Thaai Kizhavi*, which released late February, is still running in theatres and will likely drop on JioHotstar next month. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



INTERVIEW

PULLING OFF A POWER MOVE

With *Thaai Kizhavi*'s ₹75 crore-plus run and OTT release soon, actor Radikaa Sarathkumar rewrites rules on profit-sharing and ageing heroines in Tamil films

my mentor Bharathiraja's *Kizhakku Chemayile* (1993), which gave me a fresh lease in films. The television serial *Chithi* transformed how people saw me," she says. The last two years have seen Tamil cinema being kind to elderly female leads. In 2024, Urvasi shone in *J Baby*, and Geetha Kallasan in the much-celebrated *Angammal* in 2025. *Thaai Kizhavi* keeps up with that.

The actor says she was lucky to work in the 80s, when "we were allowed to make mistakes and learn". She remains a student of

cinema. "I look forward to going on set. I prepare. I don't see the monitor. I look at the director's face. That tells me what I need to know." That is why, she decided at 10.30 one night to redub for *Thaai Kizhavi*. "I could then see the joy on Sivakumar's face." Among friends, Radikaa is known for her sense of humour. However, on screen and off it, she is regarded as a strict teacher. "In the public space, when someone crosses a line with me or anyone else, I put them in their place. That's my right. Many yesteryear

heroines have told me they feel protected when I am with them. As celebrities, our work is owned by people, but no one owns us."

Speaking frankly

When Radikaa, who also grew up in London, entered the film industry, her Tamil was far from perfect. Over the years, with countless roles set in the hinterland, she came to be identified as a solid performer. Her stint in Telugu helped hone her craft. Among her memorable films are Chiranjeevi-starrer *Nyamam Kanali* (1981) and Kamal Haasan-starrer romantic drama *Swathi Mathyam* (1986).

If she 'performed' in 'serious' movies, she played herself in films where she was the 'modern girl' – her Radha of the Tamil film *Rettai Vaal Kuruvi* (1987) is one for the

ages. Her fashion sense shone through. "I see fashion differently, influenced by the years I grew up abroad. In films, the first major hurdle was fighting over the clothes I'd wear. Eventually, I took ownership – I would sit with the fabric, telling customers how to cut pants and style an ensemble," she smiles.

As a veteran actor, Radikaa makes use of the goodwill she's garnered over the years to indulge in plain-speaking. "Every time I've heard or seen someone behave badly with anyone, I've raised my voice. Now, people know that with me, they'll only get an honest opinion. However, at times, I am diplomatic too," says Radikaa, who contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election from Virudhunagar as a BJP candidate.

Being a 'thinking actress' is difficult even today, Radikaa concurs. "Most men in cinema are intimidated by me. In any gathering, there's this one woman who laughs out loud, who jokes, but you cannot cross a line with her. I think that is the only deterrent that works. That said, today's heroines are much smarter than we were."

Modern family

She has charmed Gen Z, too, with her progressive take on family. Radikaa gets along very well with her actor-turned-politician husband R. Sarathkumar's former wife Chaya Devi and daughters Varalaxmi (also an actor) and Pooja. "Coming from a broken family and having seen how we were treated, I did not want anyone to feel left out," says the daughter of the late legendary actor and politician M.R. Radha and Geetha.

Radikaa insists on rephrasing the time-tested question of why fewer roles are written for women. "Ask why people don't write scripts featuring them. Figure out how to write layered stories. I kept asking Sivakumar how he managed to write such a mature script at his age (66). OTT has opened up options for nuanced content. We need to find our space and stand tall," she says, adding, "Women are trying to push themselves. They've trusted their path, broken barriers. They are the change."

The writer is a Mangaluru-based entertainment journalist covering Tamil and Kannada cinema.

Dear readers, I just want to point out that despite writing a column that, I am reliably told, regularly reaches dozens of readers all over the world, not a single one of you invited me for food and beverages this festive season. Not for Eid or Navroz or Gudi Padwa or Cheti Chand.

How do you guys sleep at night? Sad.

No matter. It's OK. Don't say anything now. I don't care. It's too late. Let's see what happens next year.

This week, for various reasons, I am reminded of an incident from my bachelor days in Mumbai, some 20 years ago. That was a different time. One had to pay for incoming mobile phone calls, mobile phones still had keyboards, and the hottest ecommerce company was Indian Railways.

I used to live in an apartment building in Wadala East. And the building was managed by a residents' association that was generally benign. In the sense that they had, of course, vague but draconian laws about every single aspect of your life, and an intimidating squad of watchmen and watchwomen. But none of these rules were enforced, and the security staff was friendly and accommodating to a fault.

The "vague but draconian" bit is very important. For instance, the building had a rudimentary gym. There was a 50-50 chance that the equipment would severely diminish your lifespan. There was a four- or five-hour slot every day that was set aside for the ladies to use the gym.

However, none of the ladies ever used the gym, and so some of us gents used the time blocks for



GETTY IMAGES / ISTOCK

calisthenic amusements. It was not a problem. Nobody had an issue. Everyone lived happily ever after.

Then one day, after brief weightlifting, I was exiting the gym, when I was accosted by a security guard. I knew him well. And I raised my hand to convey some jaunty greeting such as "Wassup bruh" or "Dudebro, what is the goss" or some such.

He did not even smile. Instead, he said: "Sir, you are now in violation of Rule No. 13, Subsection 24 of the Residents Rules and Regulation (2002). I will now have to report you to the President for necessary action."

I looked at him with considerable

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 28

R FOR RULES

When the law is weaponised, not for public good but for career advancement

Lawyalty
/lɔːˈjæltɪ/ noun
Definition: The practice of selectively, zealously, or creatively enforcing rules, regulations or laws to demonstrate loyalty, obedience or enthusiasm to a superior, leader or ruling authority.
Related forms:
Lawyalist (noun): A person who practises lawyalty.
Lawyaling (verb): The act of enforcing rules as a loyalty performance.

flabbergast. He saluted sharply, turned around and went away.

Two days later, a letter with a stern warning from the association office manager was slipped under my door. With a request to visit his office at the earliest convenience.

The office manager ushered me inside and carefully closed the door to his office. He made sure no one was eavesdropping through the windows. And then proceeded to apologise.

"Sorry, sir," he said. "The association has just elected a new president. We are all trying to impress him, you see."

Readers, turns out that the office staff and the security staff were all desperate to impress the new president. And decided that the best way to do this was to enforce all the association rules with martinet vigour.

Which was fine. I mean, rules are rules, right. So this was how it was going to be?

The office manager chuckled

discretely. "No no, sir. This is just for 2-3 weeks. Once he is happy with our loyalty, we will stop enforcing all these rules. Once in a while, we will enforce it against his enemies."

"He has enemies?"

"Yes. Mr. Prem in Flat 401, Mrs. Patel in Flat 1303 and Mr. Daftary in Flat 906 are all his enemies. So we might have to enforce rules. But don't worry. It will only be for them."

I thanked him for this insight.

But years later, as I watch the news, I realise that this is a pan-Indian, if not pan-global tendency. Where the rule is real, the law exists, but the legal enthusiasm is selective. And the enforcement is a love letter from the enforcer to the monarch.

And yet, dear reader, the English language does not have a word for this pestilence. We have words for corruption, for nepotism, for red tape. But what about these maddening shenanigans where the law is weaponised not for public good but for career advancement?

Friends, the suffering ends today. Henceforth this phenomenon will be known as: lawyalty.

Example sentence: "Fifteen minutes after the new CEO took charge, in a sudden outbreak of lawyalty, the Head of Talent announced that the 45-minute lunch break rule would now be enforced without exception."

Have you been at the receiving end of lawyalty? Send email. Your identity is safe with me.



Sidin Vadukut
helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE

Impregnable?

Both vulnerable, South deals

Bob Jones

Most American players, we believe, would open the South hand two no trump. Today's deal is from a

competition in China, where strong club systems are very popular. Our guess is that the North-South onenotrump range was 16-18 and the two-notrump rebid showed 19-20.

We can see that the diamonds

are splitting 3-3 and the jack of spades is favorably placed for declarer. Three no trump looks impregnable. What could go wrong?

South won the opening club lead in hand with the king. South didn't know about the favorable diamond split, so he tried the reasonable play of leading the king of hearts from his hand. If he could set up two heart tricks, it wouldn't matter how the diamonds split. Can you see what happened to him? East captured the king of hearts with the ace

NORTH
♠ 10 6 3
♥ 9 5 4 3
♦ Q 3
♣ A J 4 3

WEST
♠ A 8 2
♥ 8 7 6 2
♦ J 7 4
♣ 10 6 2

SOUTH
♠ Q 9 7
♥ K Q J
♦ A K 10 8 6
♣ K Q

EAST
♠ K J 5 4
♥ A 10
♦ 9 5 2
♣ 9 8 7 5

The bidding:
SOUTH 1♦
WEST Pass
NORTH 1♥
EAST Pass
2NT Pass 3NT All pass

Opening lead: Six of ♣

and shifted to the king of spades! He continued with a low spade and South had to guess the position. South reasoned, as most of us would, that East wouldn't play this way from a spade holding that included the

jack, but he might well play this way from a holding that included the ace. South rose with his queen of spades and lost four spade tricks to go with the ace of hearts and finished down one. Nice defense.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

About icons and architecture



British modernist architect Norman Foster is known for McLaren Technology Centre located in the U.K.

Berty Ashley

Born on March 29, 1869, Edwin Lutyens rose to prominence for his Tudor-influenced houses. In New Delhi, he designed a landmark residence on Raisina Hill, blending Indian and European styles. Which building is this?

Opened on March 29, 1871, by Queen Victoria, the Royal Albert Hall is one of the world's most prestigious concert venues. In 1982, a Carnatic vocalist became the first to perform here,

with the BBC broadcasting the concert. Which singer took *Sindhuhairavi raga* to the world there?

On March 29, 1974, farmers digging a well in Shaanxi, China, discovered thousands of life-sized soldiers and horses buried underground. This monumental find is named after the material used to make them. What is it called?

On March 29, 2004, Taipei 101 became the first building to exceed 500m in height. Its green hue and tiered design are inspired

by which natural material long used in construction?

I.M. Pei is known for his geometric designs. His most famous work is a 71-foot glass pyramid serving as the entrance to a major Paris museum. Name the museum.

British modernist architect Norman Foster, known for projects such as Apple Park and Wembley Stadium, also designed the McLaren Technology Centre. Built around an artificial lake, which ancient Chinese philosophy inspired its design?

Imhotep designed the Step Pyramid of Djoser at Saqqara (2630-2610 BCE). What major architectural milestone does this structure represent?

St. Peter's Basilica is famed for its massive dome, designed by the same artist who painted the ceiling of the nearby Sistine Chapel. Who was he?

Zaha Hadid was a revolutionary Iraqi-British architect known for her radical, deconstructivist and fluid designs that defied traditional geometry, earning her the nickname "Queen of the ____." Fill in the blank.

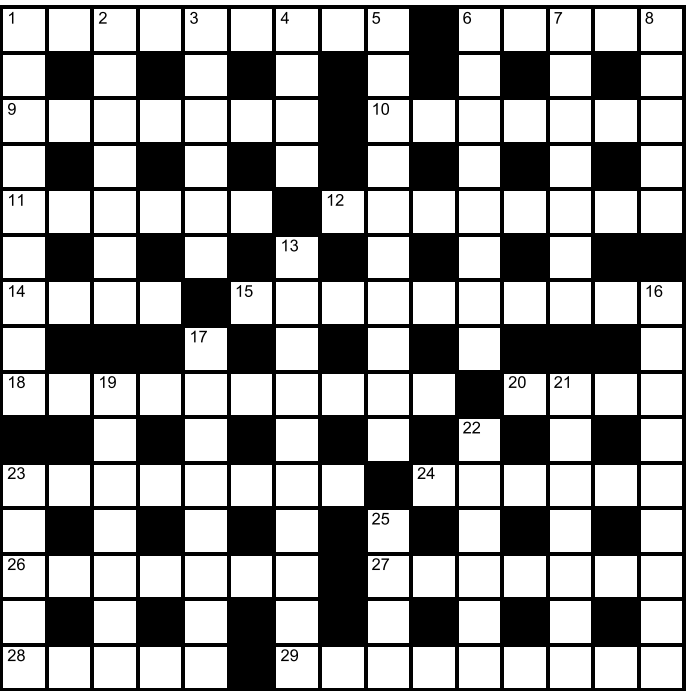
Henry Irwin, known for his Indo-Saracenic style, designed several iconic buildings across India. Which grand palace did he build for Krishnaraja Wodeyar IV in 1912?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

Answers

1. Rashtrapati Bhavan
2. M.S. Subbulakshmi
3. Terracotta Army
4. Bamboo
5. Louvre Museum
6. Yin and Yang
7. The world's first large-scale stone structure (also the earliest-known and named architecture)
8. Michelangelo
9. Curves
10. The Mysore Palace

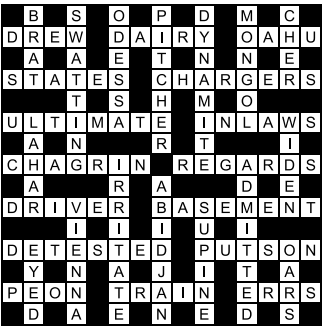
THE SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 49 Set by Vidwan



- Across**
- 1 You turn vacuous king cunningly into new generation radical reformist (5,4)
 - 6 Swami goads some comrade (5)
 - 9 At start, Kacheris are introducing a right kind of amateur singing (7)
 - 10 Core of maize peel in cooking broccoli penne (7)
 - 11 Hot thighs model for hot leotards (6)
 - 12 US City annoyed by English game (8)
 - 14 Even now one is a Himalayan mystery (4)
 - 15 Think again about fraud on team runs (10)
 - 18 Turns to fine pink under threat of sharp edged weapon (10)
 - 20 Inform on bad and good (4)
 - 23 Rock groups carried mutinous lad to barren areas in the Wild West (8)
 - 24 Country singer from India, almost through (6)
 - 26 Use one to regularly conceal plant product (7)
 - 27 English dish, possibly tortoise! (7)
 - 28 Sir! Bihar's rising right away! (5)
 - 29 Strange to live without functional sense of humour (5,4)

- 4 Fertiliser is component in agriculture activity (4)
- 5 One century separated two kings, duo ran struggling to move from place to place (4,6)
- 6 Spooner's naked sprint to paint (8)
- 7 Cut love out of decision models (7)
- 8 Sun burnt, dark shaded (5)
- 13 Latter part of Che's land reforms (6,4)
- 16 Procedure to fix married adult part (9)
- 17 Bathe and come prepared for great sacrifice (8)
- 19 Then dip around completely (2-5)
- 21 Foreword about very independent way of fertilisation (2,5)
- 22 Waterlogged planet, extremely homely (6)
- 23 Clubs having hot showers (5)
- 25 Bird with right English name (4)

SOLUTION NO. 48



- Down**
- 1 Years! Stupidly take year after year to get to Alaska's cattle! (6-3)
 - 2 Indian State, conservative and honest (7)
 - 3 Had acquired right to regularly stay unpleasant (6)

Ode to the
safety pin

Jayanthi Rangarajan
rjayanthi363@gmail.com

A simple piece of thin, elongated metal curved and coiled at just the right places, designed with quiet precision, and perfected for purpose.

Little would have Walter Hunt himself realised that his invention in 1849, the humble safety pin, designed in less than three hours, as the story goes, to pay off debts, will go on to be one of those rare creations that has slipped so seamlessly into human life. Ironically, it fetched him neither the desired returns nor the fame. We almost forget it was ever invented at all. Every time it is used, it is passed off as a mundane object, unworthy of deeper thought, insignificant for serious consideration.

The beauty of this little contraption is it is so very ubiquitous. From a child’s first days to the routines of adulthood, especially to assure one’s modesty, every human, somewhere along the way, has reached for a safety pin in urgency, in care, in improvisation. In an increasingly violent world, it stands as a testimony of how safety can be prudently practised or combined in “necessitated weaponry”.

Its brilliance lies not in complexity, but in simple restraint. A small loop for grip, a clasp for protection, a slender body that bends but does not break, it is safety, utility, and affordability distilled into a single, elegant form.

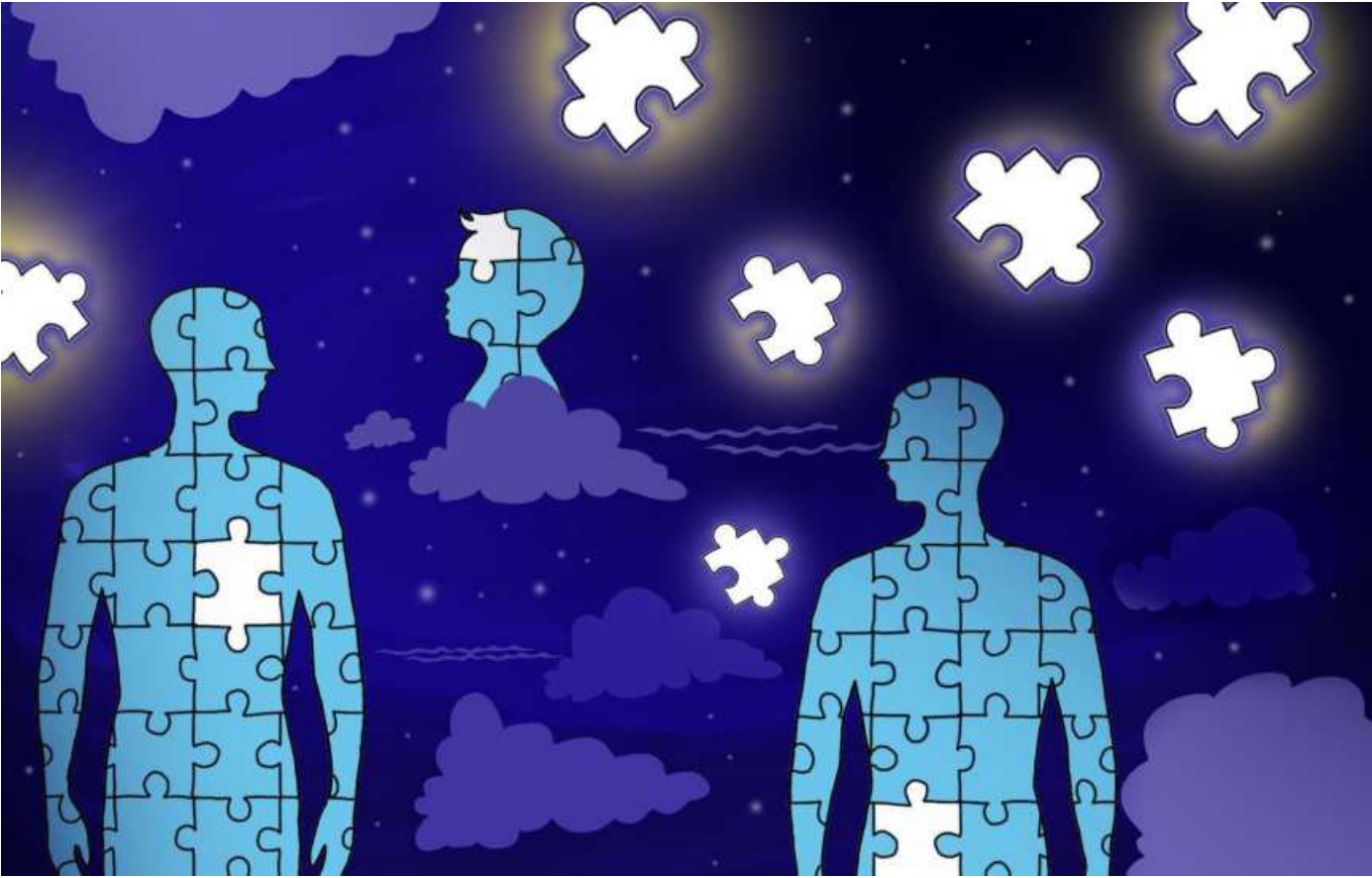
Time has tested it, and time has spared it.

In an age of endless innovation and intricate and expensive gadgets, the safety pin stands unchanged, unchallenged, quietly defying obsolescence.

A century and a half later, there is no true replacement. Even its closest contender, Velcro, with all its convenience, lacks the same precision, the same reliability, the same universal intimacy for everyday use. But beyond its function, the safety pin is a philosophy. It teaches us to be simple and humble to do one thing well, and do it with integrity.

To be unassuming to exist without seeking attention, yet always be essential.

To be affordable and accessible to all, without diminishing value. To be quietly indispensable making life easier, one small fix at a time. In a world chasing complexity, the safety pin reminds us of the power of simplicity and clarity.



When death gives a
fresh start

After demise, organs
return to dust, but if
donated in time, a
single donor can
save several lives

Viney Kirpal
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In recent episodes of his radio broadcast *Mann Ki Baat*, Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke movingly about two grieving families. One was from Amritsar, whose 39-day-old baby died after severe medical complications. Another had lost their 10-month-old child in a tragic accident. In the middle of unbearable loss, both families chose to donate their children’s organs so that other children might live.

Act of compassion
Their decision transformed private grief into a public act of compassion. Looked at differently, organ donation can change the meaning of death. What is seen as a moment of sorrow can also become a moment when one life quietly gives life to others.

Medical science today can replace failing hearts, kidneys, livers, lungs, corneas, hands, and uterus. Transplants offer thousands of patients a second chance at life. Yet the greatest obstacle is not surgical

skill; it is the shortage of organs, as 80,000 wait for an organ.

In India, organ donation is governed by the Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act. The law recognises three pathways through which organs can be donated.

The first is living donation. A healthy person, usually a close relative, can legally donate one kidney or a portion of the liver. Because the body can function normally with one kidney and the liver regenerates, the donor continues to live a healthy life.

The second pathway is deceased donation after brain-stem death, occurring usually after an accident. Brain-stem death occurs when the part of the brain that controls breathing, consciousness, and vital reflexes permanently stops functioning. The heart may still appear to beat because a ventilator pushes oxygen into the lungs, but medically the person has died. Once a specially authorised panel of doctors certifies brain-stem death as strictly defined in law, organs may be retrieved if the family consents.

A third pathway, increasingly discussed worldwide, is donation after circulatory death (DCD). Here the patient is not brain-dead but recovery is medically impossible. When life support is withdrawn and the heart finally stops beating, organs may be retrieved within a short window before they deteriorate. Many countries are expanding this form of donation, and it may become more common in India as awareness grows.

Despite these legal provisions, India’s deceased organ donation rate remains among the lowest in the world. Most organs still come from living donors of kidney and liver.

My own journey has shown me how precious each donated organ is. When I was recovering in the ICU after my heart transplant, I remember seeing a beautiful infant in another bed who desperately needed donor lungs. Because suitable organs for babies are so rare, he waited nearly three years before a match was finally found.

Children often suffer the most from this shortage.

Yet every one of us carries within our body organs that could save lives. After death, these organs eventually return to dust. But if donated in time, a single donor can save several lives and restore sight to many more.

Even when age or illness makes major organs unsuitable for transplant, tissues such as corneas, skin, bones and heart valves can still help patients.

Many families hesitate because they fear the body will be disfigured. In reality, organ retrieval teams treat the donor with great dignity. The body is carefully reconstructed so that the funeral can take place exactly as the family wishes.

The real challenge is not medical but emotional. Families must make a decision in the midst of grief. That decision becomes easier when individuals, have in their lifetime expressed their wish to donate to their loved ones.

If more Indians pledged their organs and informed their families, countless lives could be saved.

Death will come to all of us one day. But in that final moment we can choose to leave behind something more than memory. We can leave behind life itself. And in doing so, we discover a quiet form of immortality – a heartbeat, a breath, a ray of sight continuing somewhere in the world because we once lived.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Reports of Paramount studios bidding to take over Warner Bros. signals consolidation in Hollywood. (‘Eleven Oscars and a takeover’; March 22) Such mergers could reshape content monopolies, bargaining power, and global storytelling. For Indian cinema, it may mean higher investment and reach, but there is a risk of cultural homogenisation and reduced space for regional diversity.

N.S. Reddy

When a handful of corporations control studios, streaming platforms and news channels, editorial independence quietly erodes. Regulatory scrutiny is necessary, not optional.

Abbharna Barathi

Such mega-mergers often trigger layoffs, risk-averse programming, and fewer slots for original, non-franchise films. With streaming already reshaping release patterns, further consolidation could shrink creative diversity.

A. Myilsami

Beacon of courage

The conversation with Iranian writer Shahrnush Parsipur is of extreme relevance. (‘From prison to prize list’; March 22) Like the renowned Iranian poet Forugh Farrokhzad, Parsipur has been instrumental in upholding women’s freedom and self respect.

Ayyasseri Raveendranath

Mighty hills

Anuradha Roy’s book is in the manner of a bildungsroman, telling the tale of the Himalayas and



MORE ON THE WEB

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Slow death of libraries

Algorithms recommend books, narrowing exposure, while a book shelf invites wandering

Narayanan Kizhumundayur

Reclaiming childhood from devices

Create more playgrounds and safe hangout spots for children

Nishuna Sugumar

The high price of a percentile

Let parents prepare children for a life, not just for a three-hour test

Sonal Parkhe

Reflections beyond the uniform

Military writing is shaped by an instinctive awareness of what must remain unsaid

Hari Arayammakul

its adjoining mountains. (‘Life in the Himalaya’; March 22) She has adopted the style of writers such as Julian Barnes and Kazuo Ishiguro.

Aniket Mohapatra

Call to co-exist

In India, freedom of expression is a fundamental right. (‘Drawing the line’; March 22) If that gets questioned with a clear intention of creating ruckus, creativity dies, and artists bear the brunt of it.

Sajna Hameed

Beyond the rhetoric

G. Sampath’s sarcastic interpretation of the government’s rhetoric of the day made for interesting reading. (‘Dictionary of foreign policy’; March 22) Now, people know what India’s foreign policy really means.

D. Sethuraman

Honour art and artists

At a time when artists are finding it difficult to discover platforms to exhibit their talent, institutions that award talent are a godsend. (‘Bodies in motion’; March 22) Whether the art form is ancient or whether they revolve around contemporary styles, they need to be preserved.

C.V. Aravind

Channelling grief

Nina Sanadze’s initiative at Bondi Beach deserves wider recognition. (‘Creating a living memorial’; March 22) Transforming grief into something tangible and lasting is important work. What strikes me most is the democratic nature of this memorial — it belongs to ordinary people, not institutions.

S.M. Jeeva

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We confront at different points of time certain standard questions from our family and friends about our future education or career. When you are a child, the usual question you face from an adult is: “What do you want to be when you grow up?” Psychologists and educationists discourage asking this question as it is likely to pressure children to define themselves by a single job and limit their imagination to familiar roles. Yet, adults continue this practice to hear cute and amusing answers from children, though at times they are disappointed when the young ones hem and haw.

Despite the existence of a vast range of jobs in the present-day world, the reply by a primary school child to such a question is usually based on highly visible roles the child encounters in day-to-day life such as doctor, teacher, or police officer.

In modern times, however, children think of new professions such as photographer, film actor, marketing executive, automation specialist, or

The job questions

Right from childhood, people are
peppered with posers on the vocation
they will choose or are currently in



space scientist as they are exposed to media and social platforms. A pert child who was pestered by his uncle with this question asked him back whether he became what he wanted to be when he was a child. The uncle found himself on the horns of a dilemma: to say yes that was not true or to reveal that his dream of becoming a pilot was shattered!

As you enter your teens, the question encountered metamorphoses into “What do you want to study?” Barring school leavers who seek employment due to

family circumstances, boys and girls in their teens start thinking about the next stage of study. One might like to pursue professional studies but might have to be content with a degree course in arts or science as joining a professional course in a government-run institution is next to impossible for an average student of ordinary means.

Though graduate courses no longer guarantee employment, a degree is a minimum requirement for most jobs. A graduate is expected to have gained

specialised knowledge and developed critical thinking and communication skills. While doing such a course, a student must make up his mind on the next step – to seek employment, study for a Master’s degree, or join a postgraduate course in fields such as law, teaching, or automation.

Difficult juncture

Once out of the college after completing a Bachelor’s or a postgraduate degree course, the question one is asked by others, or one asks oneself, is: “What are you going to do with your degree?” In India it is a Catch-22 situation for new graduates; they cannot get a job without required experience; and they need a job to gain experience.

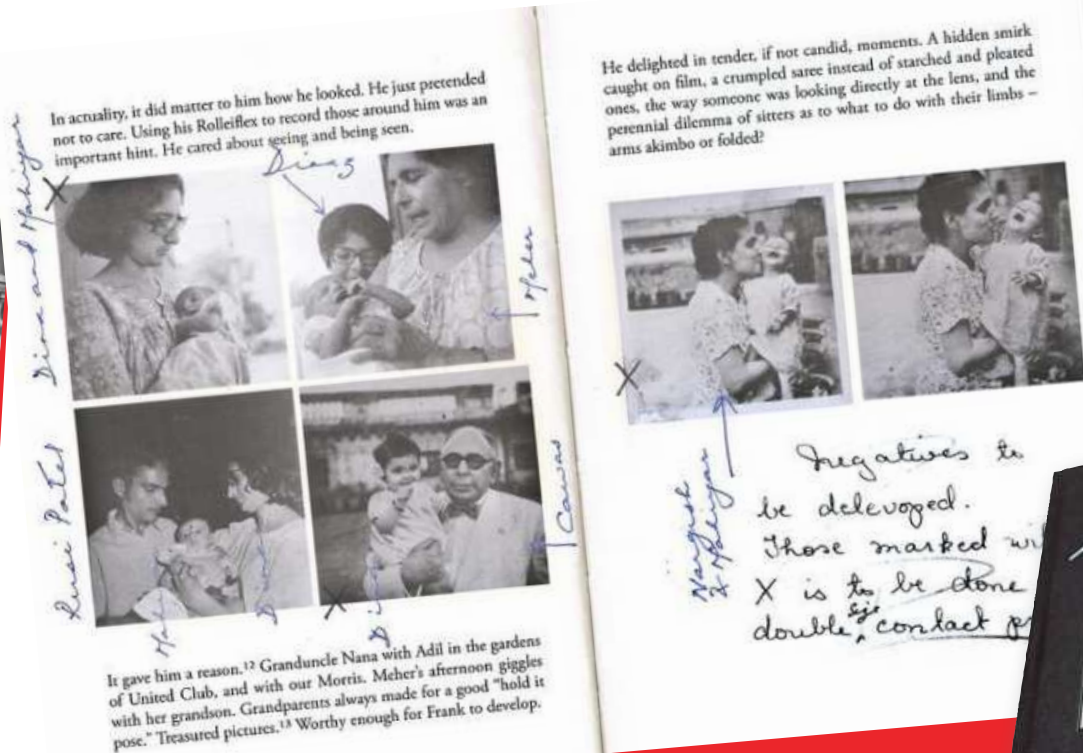
According to an ILO report, only 50% of workers hold jobs corresponding to their level of education. In India, a mere 8.25% graduates have jobs that match their qualifications, according to a survey. Many degree holders, not to speak of school leavers, remain unemployed or end up in lower skill jobs (clerk, machine operator, gig worker, cleaner), highlighting a significant skills mismatch.

Resourceful people, however, do transit from

entry-level roles to jobs compatible with their subjects of graduation or careers that are more paying, by clearing civil services and other government exams, technical training programmes, private sector jobs, overseas occupations, professional certifications, or digital fields.

Once settled in a job, a common question that crops up is “Are you satisfied with the job?” For most of the workers in India, the decision to stay in a job is a pragmatic balance where pay, prestige and security often outweigh lack of satisfaction. However, there are exceptions as in the cases of an IAS officer who resigned from his job and started teaching in a coaching institute, and a lawyer who left his career to become a musician.

Often, one’s aspirations for education and jobs do not materialise later due to several factors that include financial constraints, limited opportunities, lack of proper guidance, inaccessibility to reputable institutions, and failure to learn and adapt real world skills, to mention a few. However, developing self-confidence, resilience and perseverance would help view these challenges as opportunities for growth.



Spreads and photos from the book; and (below) *Sparseeing*. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Nishat Fatima

IN CONVERSATION

Two Alkazi Photobook Grant winners explore a new expression of the family archive

JOINING THE DOTS IN JAMSHEDPUR

Joyona Medhi met Abhishek Basu in 2015 when they interned together at *The Caravan* magazine in Delhi. Basu was the photo intern, Medhi the editorial intern. A few years later, a meeting with Varun Gazdar, owner of the Parsi café in Jamshedpur, where the two – now assistant professor at Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC, Delhi) and documentary photographer – were having coffee, would make them collaborators on a new project.

Gazdar handed them a box full of glass slides. These became the entry point to the photographic archives of the Gazdar-Bharucha family; and the world of Keki Gazdar, Varun's grandfather, who was chief electrical officer at TELCO (Tata Engineering and Locomotive Company).

The pictures also included those by Keki's father-in-law, Khurshed Bharucha, the first Indian cashier of Tata Steel, who had built the Bharucha Mansion housing a single-screen movie theatre called Regal Cinemas.

The archives became the photobook *Sparseeing*, which won the Alkazi photobook grant in 2022, and released last December (part of an accompanying exhibition at Offset Projects, Delhi). *Sparseeing* is not only a 'fictive telling' of the life of Keki, but also a record of the Parsi community in Jamshedpur, as well as a document of the rise of the steel city itself. But most of all, it is the story of a photographer in search of his vision.

As the exhibition travels to Cymroza Gallery in Mumbai in

June, the photobook's co-author Medhi decodes this new expression of the family archive. Edited excerpts:

Question: Photobooks are usually the work of photographers, but you as a writer were a part of it from the beginning. How did you approach the narrative?

Answer: We did not want to make this a story about a Parsi family. We wanted the viewer to experience it in bits and pieces and to join the dots in their own way.

Keki Gazdar was a mechanical engineer in 1950s Jamshedpur, and he used to shoot his town, visits of dignitaries, like [wrestler] Dara Singh and [Prime Minister Jawaharlal] Nehru. If you've been to Jamshedpur, it's a little like *The Truman Show* – things are too perfect. So, I wove it into the book as though Keki was trying to break from that kind of photography.

We found a diary of his, which he maintained on a cruise. He used to travel to different steel hubs like Birmingham and Brussels. In his travels, we see his photography evolving. It breaks from the straight lines and grids of Jamshedpur, to friends and family, having fun, experiencing new things. He loses his lens hood in Waterloo. There's a bit



in his diary where he's going crazy about it. It's symbolic of a man searching for his vision. We viewed it like that. We thought of him as though he's sitting in his attic, going through his old photographs, and searching for his own language. That's the narrative of the book.

Q: How did Keki Gazdar emerge as the protagonist?

A: We've not consciously tried to say that this is about

Jamshedpur or about Keki. It's about photography evolving over time. To make it more relatable, we had the photographer link. We used every picture as a prompt for us to imagine what is going on in Keki's mind; our voice is as important in the book as Keki's.

Q: There was a point in photography when looking at archives was new. Then everybody started to look at



We were very tired of photobooks where there was a lot of text. We just wanted to make it about amazing pictures. I took bits from the diaries and conversations, and integrated all of it

JOYONA MEDHI
Co-author of *Sparseeing*

them. How did you navigate keeping the book fresh?
A: I'm a social sciences student, not much into history or dates. I'm not an archivist or restorer, so, when I first saw it, it was another Parsi family

archive. Our intention was to make that interesting and relatable to someone like me. To make it cool, tactile, and also fictional, because then we step into their heads and wonder, why did he photograph this from this angle? Why did he have so much body portraiture? Keki had a bodybuilding obsession and there are a few nudes of him just posing in front of the camera, unusual for that time. There are so many pictures of parks, Dimna Lake. Why? This person was clearly obsessed. Our aim was to focus on his eccentricities.

Q: You've said the book is fictive.
A: There was a lot of material. To make sense of it from the point of view of one person [in a diary form], we've had to join the dots. When people ask me, 'What does *Sparseeing* mean?', it's to see from the point of view of the 'sparse' or to see from the point of view of fragments.

To us, Keki comes out as the protagonist because we feel as though most of the pictures have been taken by him. But he may not be also. There might be another woman, a *maasi* of his. There's one photograph of a lady signed 'me'.

This is a kind of speculative history. Everyone's image of a person is different. When I say fictive, every piece of fiction I've built, the way we've written it in our voice, is based on some snippet of information which Varun, his mother, or a relative shared. For most, Keki is a very serious

man. To break that image and show a man [from Varun's interviews] who loved swimming, new experiences, travelling, hosting flower shows, bravery awards, who was eccentric... We built that over time.

Q: How did you and Abhishek work this book out?

A: We fought. We were very tired of photobooks where there was a lot of text and over-explanation of things. We just wanted to make it about amazing pictures. Whenever we picked up a picture, we were like, 'Whoa, this picture is so cool. Other people should see it.' We selected a bunch of amazing pictures. After that, I started weaving the narrative. Once he sequenced it, it should flow like a diary. I took bits from the diaries and conversations, and integrated all of it.

Q: Yours is one of the most accessibly priced photobooks at ₹1,290.

A: I've never bought books which are ₹4,000. Yes, a photobook is an art book, but the pricing is consciously done because I want many people to pick it up. It could happen because it's supported by Tata Trusts, Alkazi Foundation, and Offset Projects. It's educational, and we want as many young researchers, writers, photographers to pick it up. I want it to be dog eared and underlined and scratched and made your own.

The author is a photographer and writer.

As a little girl, my world was filled with stories. My mother would tell us about a poor hat maker, whose hats were stolen by the monkeys when he stopped to rest at a stream. The ending, how he saved his creations by getting the monkeys to copy his actions, would send me and my brother into peals of laughter.

My grandfather would scare us with stories of the *brahmabrahmchoak* (a supernatural entity with a *tchoang*, or clay oil lamp, on its head), with the power to distract people so they ended up getting lost. We would all pray that we never met this *brahmabrahmchoak*.

It was a childhood where ghouls, ghosts and people danced together every night. But of all the stories I heard, my favourite was the one I heard about Phuphee.

Phuphee's husband, *abbaji* as we called him, would gather us and bribe us with sweet treats from his *pheran* pocket, usually *lydes* (a soft biscuit made of flour kneaded in sugar syrup, flavoured with cardamom, and fried in ghee). The biscuit would melt in our mouths as he would narrate the story. He would ask us if we knew why every man who got married in the village was given a white *kangri* (a portable earthenware heater) on his wedding day? We had heard the story before, but wanting to hear it again we would reply 'kyazi [why?]'.

Abbaji would move closer to us and whisper that a long time ago, Phuphee got so angry with the villagers, she took the warmth from every *daan* (mud stove) and *kangri*



A LITTLE LIFE

No more sending her back

Phuphee's lesson in marriage that took the heat from every hearth until men learnt the weight of carelessly said words

in the village. A marriage had taken place in the village and a few weeks later, the couple had had an argument. The husband had taunted his bride with the words, '*Gatchh telli waapas panun garre* [then go back to your own home]', referring to her maternal home. This had confused the new bride because she had been told all her life that when she got married, her

husband's home would be her home.

Every time they had a disagreement, he would repeat this, and each time, the doubt that had been planted in her mind took root deeper and deeper. She thought, if her maternal home isn't her home and this new home isn't hers either, then where exactly was her home? One day when she had become

exhausted from all the questions, she got up and left. She bought an empty cow shed near the stream (that was all she could afford) and started living there. The village was in uproar. People tried to convince her that men said these things to their wives all the time and you simply had to put up with it or, better still, ignore it. She would always reply, '*Magar mye kattiy chu*

garre telli [but where is my home then?]' She would be met with silence or bewildered faces.

Her husband was told by people that he needed to do something to control his wife. Feeling the pressure to prove his manhood, he dressed up as a bandit and scared the poor woman during the dark hours of the night. Terrified, she ran into the deep end of the stream and drowned. Her body was discovered the next day by a local woman, floating under a sheet of ice that had formed over her body as the temperatures plummeted during the night.

The woman had run to get Phuphee and both had broken through the sheet of ice and dragged her out. It is said that despite knowing she had passed away, Phuphee had taken off her own *pheran* and scarf, and tried to warm her.

Phuphee then gathered the local gravediggers and the *imam*, and the woman had been buried close to her little shed. After the burial, Phuphee walked into the heart of the village. Some villagers said her face had gone pale, as if there wasn't a drop of blood in her body; others said they couldn't make out her pupils or the irises in her eyes – they were completely white.

She had stood there and declared that though the fires may burn, they would provide no warmth. Not until every man and woman in the village came to her and took an oath that they would never repeat the dreaded words '*gatchh telli garre wapas*'.

The frightened villagers ran home, only to find out that she was

right. Though the *daan* burned and *kangris* were lit, there was no warmth. And it was the middle of *chillai kalaan*, the dreaded period of 40 days when intense cold weather sets in.

At first the villagers resisted, not knowing Phuphee's resolve. After three days, when people started falling ill, they finally understood she would not budge unless they all took the oath. So, one by one, everyone went to Phuphee's house and took an oath.

It is said that even today, when a couple gets married in the village, the groom is given a white *kangri*, to remind him of what the callousness of the human tongue could do and to make sure that no woman ever ends up losing her home again.

We sat still, listening, enraptured by the tale. I would often run to Phuphee to ask her if the story was true? She would always look at me, pretending to be shocked by the accusation, and say, 'Have you ever seen me do any magic? Your uncle has an overactive imagination and an abundance of time to waste. I am but a simple woman.'

I would sit there confused. I had been watching her all my life and though there were no abracadabra moments, there was definitely something. Something that I didn't know how to describe in words – not yet anyway.

Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life's vagaries.

